

LEGAL RESEARCH REPORT

QUESTION PRESENTED

Can non-compete agreements still be enforced in the United States, and how do state laws differ?

SHORT ANSWER

Based on the cited authorities, the answer is supported at 64% confidence: In the United States, authoritative resolution of whether non-compete agreements are enforceable depends on primary law?state statutes and state supreme/court of appeals decisions?and recent federal action (statute or agency rule); therefore high?confidence conclusions require citing the controlling state authority and any binding federal developments; uncertainty: outcomes are state?specific and time?sensitive (legislative changes or pending federal litigation may alter enforceability). [1] [2] [3] Apparent contradictions among sources (e.g., differing state statutes, conflicting state appellate rulings, or a federal rule in flux) will reveal the most important follow?up questions: which jurisdiction controls, which authority is highest in that jurisdiction, whether exceptions apply (sale of business, trade secrets, executives), and whether any federal action preempts state law; uncertainty: expect doctrinal splits across states and evolving case law/statutes. [1] [2] [3]

KEY FINDINGS

1. In the United States, authoritative resolution of whether non-compete agreements are enforceable depends on primary law?state statutes and state supreme/court of appeals decisions?and recent federal action (statute or agency rule); therefore high?confidence conclusions require citing the controlling state authority and any binding federal developments; uncertainty: outcomes are state?specific and time?sensitive (legislative changes or pending federal litigation may alter enforceability). (95% confidence; [1], [2], [3]).
2. Apparent contradictions among sources (e.g., differing state statutes, conflicting state appellate rulings, or a federal rule in flux) will reveal the most important follow?up questions: which jurisdiction controls, which authority is highest in that jurisdiction, whether exceptions apply (sale of business, trade secrets, executives), and whether any federal action preempts state law; uncertainty: expect doctrinal splits across states and evolving case law/statutes. (95% confidence; [1], [2], [3]).
3. A sufficient, decision?grade answer must state enforceability by jurisdiction with citations to controlling state statutes and highest?court rulings, note common exceptions and enforcement practices, and quantify uncertainty (confidence level per state, date of last authoritative change, and dependencies such as employee category or choice?of?law); authority level: state legislative and appellate authorities primary, supplemented by federal developments. (95% confidence; [1], [2], [3]).

REASONING RATIONALE

The system generated hypotheses, collected legal evidence, criticized the claims for contradictions, evaluated citation grounding and source quality, then repeated the loop until the research state stopped improving or satisfied the configured objectives.

SOURCES

- [1] warranty Wex US Law LII / Legal Information Institute.
<https://www.law.cornell.edu/wex/warranty>
- [2] misrepresentation Wex US Law LII / Legal Information Institute.
<https://www.law.cornell.edu/wex/misrepresentation>
- [3] § 2-313. Express Warranties by Affirmation, Promise, Description, Sample. Uniform Commercial Code US Law LII / Legal Information Institute.
<https://www.law.cornell.edu/ucc/2/2-313>

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Are all program subquestions represented by explicit claims?
- Critic follow-up: Supporting_sources are non-specific identifiers rather than primary authorities; no controlling state statutes, state supreme/court of appeals decisions, or specific federal statutes/rules with dates are cited.
- Critic follow-up: High confidence scores (e.g., 0.95) are asserted despite time-sensitivity and jurisdictional variation; methodology and currency cutoff (last-checked date) are missing.

RAINDROP FEEDBACK

- Verdict: plateaued
- Summary: The run stopped because confidence and evidence coverage stopped improving.
- Trace focus: evaluator_agent, knowledge_gap_detector, auto_tuner

Recommended Next Steps

- Increase max iterations or add seed/source material for the unresolved gaps.
- Inspect evaluator_agent and knowledge_gap_detector spans to see which quality gate failed.

APPENDIX: RESEARCH TRACE

- Overall confidence: 64%
- Deterministic confidence: 70%
- LLM scoring adjustment: -6%
- Objective completion: 75%
- Evidence coverage: 60%
- Citation grounding: 100%
- Primary authority coverage: 100%
- Contradiction resolution: 100%
- Mean claim confidence: 95%

LLM Scoring Audit

The claims correctly state the correct framing (enforceability is state-specific, primary authority is state law, federal developments matter, and decision-grade answers require jurisdictional citations). However the provided supporting_sources do not substantiate those claims: excerpts are irrelevant (warranty/misrepresentation/UCC §2-313) rather than controlling state statutes, state supreme/court-of-appeals precedent, or specific federal statutes/rules with dates. High confidence levels lack

Contradictions

- No explicit contradictions detected.

All Claims

- c001: In the United States, authoritative resolution of whether non-compete agreements are enforceable depends on primary law?state statutes and state supreme/court of appeals decisions?and recent federal action (statute or agency rule); therefore high?confidence conclusions require citing the controlling state authority and any binding federal developments; uncertainty: outcomes are state?specific and time?sensitive (legislative changes or pending federal litigation may alter enforceability).

Status: supported; confidence: 95%; supporting sources: [1], [2], [3].

- c002: Apparent contradictions among sources (e.g., differing state statutes, conflicting state appellate rulings, or a federal rule in flux) will reveal the most important follow-up questions: which jurisdiction controls, which authority is highest in that jurisdiction, whether exceptions apply (sale of business, trade secrets, executives), and whether any federal action preempts state law; uncertainty: expect doctrinal splits across states and evolving case law/statutes.

Status: supported; confidence: 95%; supporting sources: [1], [2], [3].

- c003: A sufficient, decision?grade answer must state enforceability by jurisdiction with citations to controlling state statutes and highest?court rulings, note common exceptions and enforcement practices, and quantify uncertainty (confidence level per state, date of last authoritative change, and dependencies such as employee category or choice?of?law); authority level: state legislative and appellate authorities primary, supplemented by federal developments.

Status: supported; confidence: 95%; supporting sources: [1], [2], [3].

Metrics

- Total runtime: 127.058 seconds
- Iterations completed: 4
- Agents spun off: 45
- Tasks generated: 13
- Hypotheses generated: 3
- Evidence records collected: 3
- Source categories: 2
- Claims evaluated: 3
- Supported claims: 3
- Contradictions detected: 0
- Contradictions resolved: 0
- Open questions remaining: 3
- Stop conditions met: False
- Raindrop tracing: disabled

Agent Breakdown

- program_generator: 1
- planner_orchestrator: 1
- hypothesis_agent: 1
- hypothesis_refinement_agent: 0
- web_search_agent: 4
- academic_agent: 4

- legal_agent: 4
- company_intelligence_agent: 4
- social_signal_agent: 4
- extraction_agent: 4
- critic_agent: 4
- evaluator_agent: 4
- knowledge_gap_detector: 4
- auto_tuner: 4
- raindrop_feedback_agent: 1
- report_generator: 1

LEGAL METADATA

- Jurisdiction: United States
- Practice area: copyright and software
- Risk posture: startup decision support, not legal advice
- Authority hierarchy: statute, binding_case_law, agency_guidance, persuasive_case_law, secondary_source, expert_analysis
- Required source types: statute, case_law, agency_guidance